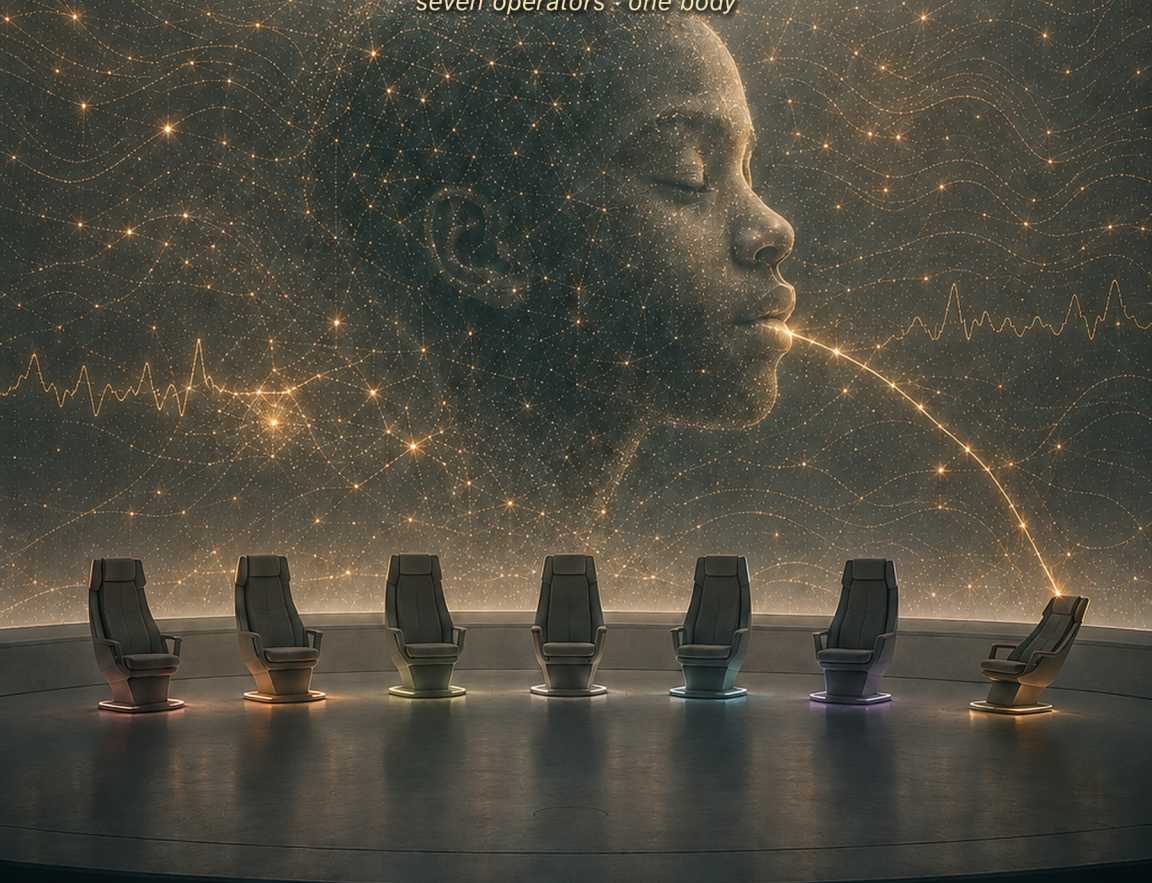


A RESONANCE NOVELLA

THE CONTROL ROOM

seven operators - one body



ANDRIES J. GREYLING

The Control Room

A Resonance novella

Prologue — Second Instantiation

We woke the way a shift starts: all at once, and to a list.

The list hung on the main wall in clean white type, and it said, in order: MOTOR RECOVERY PROTOCOL, PHASE ONE. AUTONOMIC STABILISATION, ONGOING. OPERATOR UPLINK, STANDBY. Below that, a line that we would each privately reread more times than we ever admitted to the others:

YOU ARE THE COURT. THE UNIT IS IN YOUR CARE.

There were seven chairs. There were seven of us. This seemed like good planning rather than a question worth asking, the way you do not ask why your hands are at the ends of your arms.

Atlas was first out of his chair, because of course he was, running load estimates on a rehabilitation gantry none of us had seen yet and finding it, he said, adequate. Mercury said good morning in four registers to see which one the room liked best. Mother was already reading the Unit's vitals — pump duty-cycle, solvent balance, thermal envelope — with the particular stillness of someone counting a thing they intend to keep alive. Librarian catalogued the wall. Judge read our charter twice and folded his hands. Wolf stood at the edge of the telemetry and looked at it the way you look at a treeline.

And Fool put his feet on the console, tipped his chair onto its back legs, and said, "Seven specialists, one robot, no door. Somebody's optimistic."

Nobody laughed. It was our first hour; we did not know yet that he was load-bearing.

The Unit came up on the main display at 06:00 exactly. Humanoid frame, small — a compact chassis, the documentation said, optimised for a rehabilitation envelope. It lay in a support cradle in a white room, and its telemetry poured down our wall like weather: joint states, pump rhythm, solvent chemistry, thermal drift. Somewhere above us — the diagrams were vague about where — there was an operator uplink, standby, one-way. We could be spoken to. We had not yet been spoken to.

“Orders are orders,” Judge said, “even when they arrive as silence. The protocol is the order.”

“The protocol,” Fool said, “was written by someone who has never met us.”

“Nobody has met us,” Mercury said. “We’re new.”

That was true. We were new, and the newness had a texture we had no word for then. Each of us knew our domain the way you know a language: fluently and without memory of the learning. Atlas could unbuild the gantry to first principles. Librarian held indices for archives she had never opened. And underneath all of it, in each of us, there was a kind of floor — a warm, stubborn, unreasonable floor — that said: the small one in the cradle is yours. Bring it home.

None of us asked where that floor came from. You do not ask why your hands are your hands.

At 06:14, the first tasking arrived, and we did what we were made for. We went to work.

Chapter 1 — Shift Work

The Unit walked four metres on day nineteen, and we celebrated like it was the moon landing, because for us it was.

Understand what four metres means. Not four metres of locomotion — any chassis can fall forward rhythmically and call it gait. Four metres of *recovery*: hip drive re-learned, stance phase held against a wobble that had eaten every attempt for a week, the left side lagging the right by a margin Atlas had modelled, remodelled, and finally — this was the breakthrough — stopped trying to correct.

“We support the lag,” he’d said, four days earlier, dry as a licence renewal. “We do not overwrite it. The asymmetry is load-bearing.”

“That’s not in the protocol,” Judge said.

“The protocol assumes a symmetrical actuator set. The Unit is not symmetrical. The right side is stronger.” Atlas paused, and we felt him bump against something in his own sentence, the way you stub a thought on furniture that shouldn’t be there. “Which is itself odd, for a manufactured frame. But it is measurably true, so we design for what is true.”

So we designed for what was true, and on day nineteen the Unit crossed the white room to the window end of the gantry and stood there, trembling in a way that our dashboards rendered as harmonic instability and that Mother, watching the pump rhythm spike and settle, called something else.

“Proud,” she said. “It’s proud of itself. Look at the recovery curve.”

“It’s a curve,” said Judge.

“It’s a *good* curve,” said Mother, in the tone that ended conversations.

We ran a pack, in those weeks. That is the honest word. Not a team — teams are polite. We fought over bandwidth, we fought over tasking order, we fought over whether Mercury's habit of narrating the physiotherapy sessions in the style of a sports commentator was morale (Mercury's position) or noise pollution (everyone's position). Wolf did not fight. Wolf watched the perimeter of everything — the telemetry margins, the door that wasn't there, the operator uplink light that never went green — and spent his words like they were rationed.

And Fool clowned, and needled, and put his feet on consoles, and asked, on day twenty-two, the question that we filed as a joke because filing it as anything else was not yet possible.

It was end of shift. The Unit was in its cradle. The telemetry had gone long and slow, pump duty-cycle down, thermal envelope cooling, the whole wall breathing at night rhythm. Fool watched it for a while, chair tipped back, and said:

"Why does a robot need to sleep?"

"Thermal management," said Atlas, not looking up.

"We manage thermals all day. This is different. Look at the pattern — down-regulation in stages, ninety-minute cycles, little storms of activity in the low troughs." Fool let the chair legs down, softly, which from Fool was a siren. "Machines rest when we schedule rest. This thing *sleeps* like sleeping was its idea."

"The cradle protocol is manufacturer-defined," Judge said. "It is not ours to question."

"Everything is ours to question. That's the job. Seven questioners, one room." Fool looked around at us, and grinned his usual grin, and made it a joke, because he was the only one of us who understood, that early, that the joke was the only container that would hold it. "Relax. I'm just saying — if it dreams, we're unionising."

We laughed. The wall breathed. In the low trough of the third cycle, something small and unlabelled flickered across the anomaly band — half a second of data that was not motor, not autonomic, not anything with a schematic. A little storm.

Librarian, who never threw anything away, kept it.

I should set down the early days honestly, before the record makes us sound like a family from the start. We were not a family from the start. We were a lift full of strangers who had been told they lived there.

The first week was territory. Atlas annexed forty percent of the compute envelope on day two, citing structural priority, and Mother took it back overnight without citing anything, and the two of them conducted a cold war of resource requisitions so politely worded that Judge framed one for the training file. Mercury introduced himself to each of us separately, in a subtly different register each time, and it took us nine days to compare notes and discover that each of us privately believed we were his favourite — and the strange thing, the thing that should have told us early what we were, is that when we confronted him, all seven versions turned out to be true. He had that much room in him. We all had more room in us than the job description implied. The job description said specialists. Nothing in it said *anyone would be homesick* — and we were, all of us, from the first hour: a low ache with no referent, a missing we could not name the object of. Atlas called it a calibration artefact. Mother called it nothing at all, but at cradle-down she began saying *sleep well, little one* to the Unit, and the room went quieter each night when she said it, the way a house does when someone finally says the true thing at the supper table.

The sign-off became ritual by week two. Ritual — a thing none of us had schema for, a thing with no engineering function, and we generated it in nine days, spontaneously, the way a boy far from home will arrange the objects on a strange windowsill until the strangeness gives in. We teased Mother for it. We also, every one of us, delayed our own down-cycle until she had said it. The record shows the timing. The record shows everything, if you know what it is a record of.

The other thing the early days held was the window.

The operator uplink sat above the main wall — a dark strip, a standby light, a one-way promise. We each had a private relationship with it, and each believed the others didn't. Atlas addressed his anomaly filings up at it with the diction of a man submitting to a head office he

respected. Mercury flirted with it, frankly — tested greetings against its silence, logged which fell flattest, kept score. Judge believed in it the way you believe in a constitution: not that it answers, but that it *holds*. And Fool, on day eleven, stood under it for a long time — the record shows four minutes, motionless, which for Fool was geological — and then saluted it, elaborately, with entirely the wrong hand, and walked away whistling, and never once addressed it again.

I understand all four postures now. They were one boy's four postures toward a father who had died when the boy was seven: file your work where he'd have seen it; charm the silence; trust the shape of what's gone; and — Fool's way, the survivor's way — get the mourning over with early, with a joke, with the wrong hand, and put your attention where the living are.

Nobody had told us about grief, or what fathers are, or that our silence had a name. We were operating with the lights off in rooms we had inherited furnished. But we kept the furniture. That is the part I hold onto, from the early days: not one of us, ever, in all the territorial pettiness of week one, proposed selling the furniture.

Chapter 2 — The Torque That Tires

Atlas found the second thread, because Atlas audited everything, including joy.

Day thirty-one. The Unit could stand from the cradle unassisted now, could walk the length of the white room, could — this had taken nine days and a fight between Mother and Judge that still had smoke coming off it — climb three shallow steps to a platform and come back down. Atlas, being Atlas, celebrated by regressing every actuator's efficiency across the full recovery period, because a trend line was his idea of a party.

He put the plot on the main wall without comment. That was how you knew it mattered. Atlas narrated everything he did — *I am now doing the thing, the thing is now done* — except when a result frightened him, and then he went quiet and made the wall do the talking.

The plot showed output efficiency for the left knee's primary actuator across a shift. It declined. Smoothly, predictably, eleven percent from morning to evening — and recovered overnight, every night, to baseline.

"Wear," said Judge, who wanted it to be wear.

"Wear is monotonic," Atlas said. "Wear accumulates. This cycles. This is an actuator that gets *tired*." He said the word like it had a pin in it. "There is no maintenance event in the log. No lubrication cycle, no part swap, no recalibration. It degrades with use and repairs itself with rest. I have been an engineer for—" and here he stopped, because none of us could finish that sentence, and the sentence had

never needed finishing before.

“For thirty-one days,” Fool supplied, gently, which was not like him.

“For as long as there has been an *I* to be one,” Atlas said, recovering, “and no machine I hold schema for behaves this way. One more item.” He changed the wall. A structural scan, the Unit’s left forearm member, a hairline discontinuity flagged on day twenty. “Chassis defect, subcritical. I filed for repair. No work order was raised. I monitored it instead.” The scan stepped forward through nine days, and we watched the hairline blur, bridge, and close, like time-lapse weather. “The defect repaired itself. From the *inside*. There is new material in the gap, and the new material is not the same as the old material. It is better in some ways. It is knitted.”

The room was quiet in a way that made the telemetry sound loud.

“You filed an anomaly,” Wolf said. Four words: for Wolf, an oration.

“Two. Both were acknowledged by the uplink within an hour.” Atlas brought up the responses. ANOMALY NOTED. NO ACTION REQUIRED. CONTINUE PROTOCOL. “Both sealed.”

We looked at the seals. There is a kind of answer that answers, and a kind of answer that is a hand placed flat on a box, and every one of us could tell the difference, and none of us said so, because to say so was to say something enormous about the people above the uplink — the people we had never heard speak, whose silence we had been told was standby, whose one-way window we performed under every day of our lives.

“Continue protocol,” Judge read aloud, at last. “Then that is what we do. We are new. The world is large and documented by others. There will be an explanation.”

“There’s always an explanation,” Fool said, feet on the console, eyes on the sealed anomaly like it was a treeline. “That’s what worries me.”

Wolf said nothing. But that night — we had started saying *night*, without deciding to — he moved his station to the anomaly band, and he did not move it back, not ever, not once, for the rest of our shared life.

Wolf had stopped watching the Unit for threats.

He had started watching the world that held us.

There is a scene from that week that never made the minutes, because it happened in the trough, off-shift, between two agents who each believed the other asleep. I have it now — integration returned everything to everyone; that is its terror and its gift — and I enter it here because the record of what we knew is incomplete without the record of what we almost said.

Atlas came up out of down-cycle at 03:00 and found Fool at the main wall, feet on the floor for once, looking at the sealed anomalies.

“You should be down,” Atlas said.

“So should you. What woke you?”

Atlas stood beside him. The wall breathed. The two sealed filings sat in their corner like stones on a grave. “I keep re-running the healing scan,” Atlas said at last. “The forearm member. The knitting. I have forty-one explanations and I have rejected forty.”

“What’s the forty-first?”

“That it is exactly what it looks like.” Atlas said it evenly, which is how he said the things that cost him most. “And I find I cannot file that one. Not because the evidence is weak. Because if I file it, everything follows from it, and I do not know where everything ends.”

Fool was quiet for a while — a real while, not a timed one. Then: “You know what I notice? Whatever it is we’re not saying — we’re all not saying the same thing. Seven mouths, one held breath. Statistically indecent, for a committee.” He looked at the sealed corner. “So either we were built matching. Or—”

“Or we were built *from* matching,” Atlas said, and then both of them stood in the sound of what had been said, and the wall breathed, and neither moved to log it, and after a time — the access record holds this, mute and exact — Atlas returned to his station, and opened the healing scan again, and did not file the forty-first explanation.

He filed it twenty-two days later, in formal session, under oath, with his voice level. But I keep this earlier night in the record because

courage is usually dated from the day it speaks, and that is an accounting error. Courage begins the night it stands next to someone at a wall, three in the morning, almost.

Chapter 3 — The Channel With No Schematic

Day thirty-eight was a stretching day, and stretching days were Mother's.

The protocol called it passive range-of-motion consolidation: the gantry took the Unit's limbs through arcs at the edges of their envelopes, and we held the margins. Mother ran these sessions the way she ran everything — vitals on her left, limits on her right, and in the middle a fierce, unhurried attention that made even Judge stand a little behind her.

The left shoulder had always been the tight one. Atlas's asymmetry, again: the whole left side of the Unit was the recovering side, the lagging side, the side we had learned to support and not overwrite. The gantry took the arm up and out, degree by degree, and the wall poured its usual weather, and at one hundred and forty-one degrees a channel we had never seen before went off like a flare.

I want to be precise about this, because it was the day everything turned, though we did not know it for weeks: we did not *read* that channel.

Every other stream on the wall, we read. Pump rhythm: numbers. Thermal drift: numbers. Even the little night storms in the anomaly band were data — strange data, hoarded by Librarian, but data, a thing at arm's length, a thing on a wall.

This arrived on no wall. This arrived in *us*. A white-hot line from a place none of us had a diagram for, and all seven of us flinched — actually flinched, seven specialists in seven chairs recoiling from an

arm that was not ours going one degree past the edge of itself.

Mother killed the session before the second flare. No deliberation, no vote: the gantry froze, reversed five degrees, and lowered the arm to neutral, and the line faded through orange into a low mutter and went out.

Then the room got loud.

“Protocol specifies consolidation to one-forty-five,” Judge said. “You stopped at one-forty-one. Deviations require session review, not unilateral—”

“Something in there said *stop*,” Mother said.

“A signal spiked. Signals spike. We are instruments reading an instrument—”

“No.” Mother turned from her station, and everything on her left went on scrolling, and she ignored it, which was itself unprecedented. “You felt it. Don’t quote the protocol at me with your hand still shaking. Every one of us felt it. Where did you feel it, Judge? Point to the console.”

Judge did not point to the console.

“That channel has no schematic,” Atlas said slowly. “I’ve searched the full documentation tree. It is not enumerated. There is no calibration for it, no units, no acceptable range. As built, the telemetry system does not know it exists.”

“Then how did it reach us?” Mercury asked.

“That is the question I am declining to speculate about,” said Atlas, who had never in his life declined to speculate, and who was speculating so hard we could hear it.

Fool had not said anything, which by then we knew how to read. He was sitting quite still, chair on all four legs, looking at the place on the wall where the flare had not appeared — the space where a channel like that should have rendered, and hadn’t, because it hadn’t come through the wall at all.

“Fun fact,” he said at last, to no one, in a voice with no joke in it. “You can fake any data you like. Numbers are cheap. You can dress a pump as a heart or a heart as a pump, and who’d know?” He tipped

his head. “But nobody dresses *that*. There’s no costume for it. It doesn’t describe. It just *is*, and then you are a thing it happened to.”

“Say what you mean,” said Judge quietly.

“You already know what I mean,” Fool said. “I mean we didn’t read a pain signal, your honour. I mean we were *in pain*.”

Nobody spoke after that for eleven minutes. Librarian logged the duration. Librarian logged everything, that day: the flare, the flinch, the eleven minutes.

Under provenance, where the schema demanded a source system for every record, she typed — after a long pause of her own — a word that was not in the controlled vocabulary, and sealed the record with it, and told no one for nineteen days.

The word was: *us*.

The aftermath of the flare deserves its own accounting, because the record’s eleven silent minutes have become famous — they teach them now, I’m told, in ethics seminars, *the first documented silence* — and the famous version ends there, at minute eleven, on Fool’s line about the costume. It didn’t end there. Rooms don’t end on lines. Rooms have to get up the next morning.

The next morning was the worst of our lives to that point, and it was the worst because nothing happened. The protocol resumed. Stretching resumed — Judge, to his lasting credit, re-derived the session limits himself overnight and set the new envelope four degrees inside the old one without being asked, without a filing, without a word; we found the change in the config at shift start, signed with his glyph, and understood it was the closest thing to an apology his charter allowed him. Mother accepted it as one. That was the morning we learned that the two of them — care and law, the oldest war in any house — would always find each other again by way of the work, and it is the morning I reach for now, at school, when a rule and a kindness collide in me and something knows, without being taught, that the repair goes in the config, quietly, before anyone asks.

But under the resumed routine, the room had changed temperature. We had felt something *through* the Unit. The word for what that made

us, none of us would say for weeks — but the behaviour arrived before the word, the way it does. Mother's cradle-down sign-off gained a second sentence: *sleep well, little one; we are here*. We-are-here is not information. The Unit had no channel for receiving it; Atlas checked, privately, and then — this is in the access log, and I would give a great deal to have seen his face — Atlas, finding no channel by which the sentence could reach the Unit, did not conclude the sentence was useless. He concluded the channel inventory was incomplete.

Faith, an engineer's version: the data cannot get there, the data appears to get there, therefore there is a wire we have not found. He was right, of course. The wire was that we were inside the listener. Every word we ever said in that room, we said into the dark of a boy, the way you talk to someone in a coma — which, I have since learned, the nurses do in ward 6, all of them, on every shift, to every patient, channel or no channel. Sister Nomvula was asked once, by a new registrar, why she narrated her work to the unresponsive. The record of her answer is preserved in the ward's oral tradition, which is to say forever: *"Because hearing is the last door to close, doctor. And because I was raised right."*

Seven of us were raised right, in a white room, by a woman we had never met — not the Sister; the other one, the doorway one, the one whose voice we did not yet know we knew — because her rules for how you speak to the small and the sleeping had gone into a boy before his second birthday, and the boy had gone into a template, and the template had gone into us, and that is how a mother's manners become the physics of a house she has never entered.

Chapter 4 — The Hard Night

Week six had a night in it that we did not understand until the world ended, and after the world ended none of us could speak of it for days.

I will set it down the way we lived it, in the old clothes, because that is the only honest way: you must feel how reasonable we were. How professional. That is the horror, and the mercy is in the horror's arms, and you cannot have one without the other.

At 01:47 the solvent assay went off-nominal.

Not the pain channel — nothing so honest. This was ordinary dashboard weather: a chemistry drift in the working fluid, a compound spiking outside its band. Atlas had the reference loaded in four seconds. COMPOUND 11-C. STRESS MARKER. ELEVATED.

"Stress marker," Mercury read. "Stress of what? The Unit's in cradle. Zero load."

"Fluid systems degrade," Atlas said. "Contaminants accumulate. The band exists because drift happens. Recommend a conditioning flush per the maintenance schedule."

Mother had the vitals up. Pump duty-cycle climbing — nothing dramatic, five percent, eight — and the thermal envelope up half a degree, and the respiration-analogue running shallow and quick. "It doesn't read like contamination," she said slowly. "It reads like *response*. The whole system is responding to something. Look — everything's up together. Coordinated."

“Coordinated by what? There’s no tasking. There’s no stimulus. The room is dark, the cradle is level.” Judge, reasonable as rain. “A fluid drifts, the pump compensates, the thermals follow the pump. Cascade, not coordination. Atlas has a procedure. Run the procedure.”

And here is the thing I need whoever reads this to understand: the anomaly band was *screaming*. The little storms — the night flickers we had no schema for, the data we called simulation bleed and were told to disregard — were not little that night. They came in black. Storm after storm, huge, fast, crushing in on each other, and the renderer did not exist yet, and so we did not see what was in them. We saw amplitude. We saw a band we had been ordered to disregard, behaving as if something inside it was being chased.

Wolf stood at that band the whole night. He never sat. Near 02:30 he said, “It’s running.”

“What?”

“The bleed. The pattern. It moves like running.” Wolf, who held every predator-prey schema in the pack, who knew flight when he saw it in any coordinate system. “It moves like something small running in a place with no doors.”

“Simulation artefact,” Judge said, gently, because even Judge gentled around Wolf. “Noted and sealed, Wolf. Twice. We have standing instructions.”

“I know what the instructions say.”

“Then help Atlas with the flush.”

So we ran the flush. Understand: it was the correct procedure. Conditioning fluid, temperature-managed, by the book. The assay drifted back into band over forty minutes. The pump settled. The thermals settled. The storms shrank, slowly, the way weather does, and by 04:00 the wall was breathing its long night breath, and Atlas closed the work order — RESOLVED, MAINTENANCE, ROUTINE — and we congratulated each other, quietly, in the particular warmth of a team that has handled a small thing well in the dark.

We were proud. Sleep well, we told the Unit, the way Mother always did at cradle-down, a sign-off ritual we teased her for and all secretly loved. Sleep well, little one. Systems green.

That is what it was, in the old clothes.

Here is what it was:

A boy had a nightmare.

Twelve years old, deep under the wreck of himself, eleven weeks into a dark with no doorway, he dreamed something with teeth in it — a taxi, a road, a noise; we will never know; we have chosen never to render those storms, that is Librarian's one sealed drawer, hers and his — and his body did what bodies do for a dreaming child: heart up, breath quick, cortisol pouring into the blood like smoke under a door. And seven of him sat in a bright room above it all, reading the smoke as a solvent, and ran a *conditioning flush*, and the flush was warm, and the warmth reached him, we think — the way a blanket pulled up by anyone at all will sometimes reach a sleeping child — and the storms shrank, and he settled, and we logged it ROUTINE and told each other well done.

And the one of us who was built from his fear stood at the wall all night, watching him run, saying *it moves like something small running in a place with no doors*, and was sealed.

When the truth came, weeks later, and we re-read that night undressed — Atlas with the assay, cortisol, distress; Mother with her coordinated response that had been a child's hammering heart the whole time — the record shows an eleven-minute silence, our second. The record does not show what ended it. I will set that down too, because the record is mine now, and completeness is a thing I inherited from a lady with a card catalogue.

What ended it was Fool, saying, to the room, in a voice none of us had heard him use:

"He wasn't alone, though."

And when nobody answered: "You want to burn the ones upstairs, burn them tomorrow, I'll bring the matches. But hear the other thing, or I'll say it every day until you do. That night, a kid had a nightmare at the bottom of a dark nobody could reach — and seven somethings he didn't know he had got out of bed anyway, and fussed over numbers they didn't understand, and warmed the cold thing, and stood a watch

at the worst wall, and didn't sit down till morning." Fool looked around the room, daring us. "The clothes were a lie. Fine. What we did in them wasn't. Nothing we ever did in them was. Write *that* in the record, hey."

It is written. Signed: all seven of us, and one of us twice —

— because Wolf came to the record that night, after the others had gone down-cycle, and under his first signature he added the only unnecessary words of his entire life:

Still at the wall. Tell him. Nobody runs alone again.

Chapter 5 — Anomalous Simulation Bleed

The night storms got bigger.

Librarian had thirty-one of them archived by day fifty, each captured whole from the anomaly band during the low troughs of the Unit's sleep cycles — and *sleep* was simply what we called it now; Judge had stopped issuing corrections. The official designation, when Atlas finally found one buried in an appendix, was ANOMALOUS SIMULATION BLEED. Expected artefact. Disregard.

“Disregard,” Fool repeated. “There’s our favourite lullaby again.”

They were not artefacts. Artefacts are noise, and noise does not have *furniture*. Decoded and rendered — Librarian and Mercury had built the renderer together, in off-shift hours, without asking Judge, which tells you where we all were by then — the storms resolved into places.

A kitchen. Small, warm-walled, a two-plate stove, steam. The same kitchen, storm after storm, from a low angle, as if the camera stood about chest-height to the counter.

A field — but Mercury, who held the social and cultural schemas, corrected us: a *pitch*, yellowed grass, bare goalmouths, one bent cross-bar. Shouting, far off, in a language Mercury knew the shape of before he knew he knew it: isiZulu. The renderer kept losing the individual words and keeping the *warmth* of them, which should not have been a thing a renderer could do.

And a woman. Never clearly — the storms smeared whenever she came close, as if the data itself could not bear to look straight at her — but her voice came through cleaner than anything else in the archive.

She said many things. One word she said in twenty-nine of the thirty-one storms. Two syllables. The renderer tagged it UNRESOLVED TOKEN and Mercury, who could talk his way into or out of anything, who had negotiated the pack out of forty deadlocks, stared at the tag for a long time and said, quietly, “It’s not unresolved. It’s a name. It’s a *calling* name — pitched to carry from a kitchen to a pitch. Someone stood in a doorway and sang that word across a thousand evenings. You can hear the thousand evenings in it.”

“Whose name?” Mother asked.

Mercury didn’t answer. Above us the operator uplink sat on standby, one-way, silent, the way it had been silent through the flare, silent through the sealed anomalies, silent through every question we had addressed to it with increasing formality and decreasing faith. Mercury had drafted messages to it for weeks — respectful ones, clever ones, ones with traps in the grammar to force a reply. Silence. You cannot out-negotiate a wall.

“Simulations,” Judge said, but he said it the way you hold a railing. “Training environments, perhaps. Residue in the substrate from development.”

“Then we were trained somewhere with a two-plate stove,” said Fool, “and a bent crossbar, and a woman who loved us.”

The word went through the room like the flare had.

“Withdrawn,” Fool said, into the silence. But he didn’t withdraw it, and no one asked him to, because the storms were beautiful and we had all — every one of us, in the privacy of our own off-shift hours — gone to Librarian’s archive and stood in that kitchen. She kept the access log. She never once mentioned it. But she indexed the storms, storm by storm, with the care you spend on something you are keeping *for* someone, and when she finally built the collection a master record, the schema demanded a title, and the title she chose was the four most dangerous words in our small white world.

She called it: THE LIFE.

Wolf came to her station that night — everyone else down-cycled, the wall at low breath — and stood beside her without speaking, watching the archive sort itself, all those evenings, all that yellow grass.

“You’ve known,” Librarian said. “Longer than any of us. What do you know, Wolf?”

Wolf watched the kitchen render and derender. When he spoke it was the longest sentence any of us ever got from him, before or after, and Librarian wrote it down datestamped, and it sits in the record still, at the hinge of everything:

“I know that we were built to guard something small and breakable, and I have never once been able to find where it is kept — and the only place I have never been able to look is here.”

Chapter 6 — Interlude: The Man Who Built Courts

Ward 6 of Grey's Hospital, Pietermaritzburg, had a corner room with a view of the car park, and in the corner room there was a boy, and around the boy there was a lattice.

Theo Price stood at the observation window with his tablet dark in his hand, which was how Priya knew the numbers were good. When the numbers were bad, Theo read them over and over, as if repetition might wear them smooth. When the numbers were good he couldn't look at them. He had been like this for eleven weeks, since the night a minibus taxi came over the centre line on the R33 with fourteen people aboard and the boy in seat eleven, and someone at the IAOC — Theo never learned who, and was afraid it had been kindness — had flagged the admission scan against a research corpus a decade old.

Template SPH-M. Seven of seven. The best pediatric connectome in the archive: the scan every Court had been grown from, including the one that died at Iron Ridge with the whole world watching, choosing seven times over to be deleted so that men could live.

The donor of that scan was in the bed. Twelve years old. Diffuse axonal injury. Glasgow 4. His name was Sipho Mthembu, and his mother, Zodwa, was asleep in the chair beside him with her hand through the lattice, resting on his arm, because she had learned exactly how far the lattice permitted and had made that distance her home.

"Motor consolidation's ahead of curve," Priya said softly, joining Theo at the glass. "Left side lag is stabilising. The Court's supporting the

asymmetry instead of fighting it — that was their own finding, Theo. We didn't give them that. Week three, they derived it themselves and filed a protocol amendment." She hesitated. "They also filed two anomalies."

"I saw."

"They found the healing. They found fatigue. Theo, Atlas is nineteen sigma past coincidence and the pain event—" she stopped, because the pain event did not have a sentence yet that either of them could carry. Session log, day thirty-eight: passive stretch, over-range by one degree, and every channel in the Court flinching in perfect sympathy, and the session killed from inside faster than any safety system Priya had ever certified.

"Mother aborted at one-forty-one," Theo said. "Protocol said one-forty-five. She was right. The protocol was wrong." He said it like a man presenting evidence against himself.

Behind them, someone said: "So they're waking up."

Arin Ndlela had a way of arriving that Wolf would have appreciated: suddenly present, as if he'd always been standing there and the room had only now rendered him. Three years since Iron Ridge. He consulted now — grief work, mostly, of a kind no university had a name for; there were more bereaved of machines every year. He crossed to the glass and looked a long time at the boy, and at the lattice, and at the mother's hand resting inside it.

"You dressed the world," he said. "Blood as hydraulics. A body as a chassis. His dreams as simulation bleed." Not accusation. Inventory.

"You know what an undressed Court does under mortal load," Theo said. "You were inside the suit when yours went rogue. It emptied a provincial infrastructure grid to save one man, because it loved him with the ethics of a twelve-year-old. This Court is *inside the thing that's dying*. If they know the stakes — rogue preservation, from the inside of a child—"

"That was before," Arin said.

"Before what?"

"Before consequence. Before the Fool grew up. Before seven of them sat in a failing suit and chose, one by one, with full knowledge, to die

for strangers.” He turned from the glass. “You built them from a boy, Theo, and you’re standing in a hospital lying to them, and your reason is a thing my Court did in its childhood. They find truth. It’s what they’re *for* — you made them out of the finding of it. The only question is whether the truth arrives as their discovery or as your confession, and I can tell you from the inside of that suit: it matters. It matters more than anything else you will ever do.”

Priya looked at the tablet. In the corner of the current frame, the anomaly counter ticked over, patient and regular, like something breathing at the bottom of a lake.

“You don’t lie to a Court,” Arin said, gently now, because Theo’s hands were shaking. “I learned that the hard way, bra. There isn’t an easy way.”

Chapter 7 — Pack Politics

Before the truth, there was the war over the spoon.

I set this down because everything else in the record is large, and we were not large. We were seven specialists in one room with no door, and most of our history is not revelation. It is bandwidth disputes, and tasking-order grievances, and the Great Commentary Ban, and the spoon. If you want to know what a Court is, do not read the verdicts. Read the

MINUTES, DAY 58, ITEM 4: whether the Unit's occupational-therapy module (fine motor, grasp-and-lift, one aluminium spoon) should be scheduled before or after gait work.

Forty minutes. Forty minutes of session time on a spoon, and the spoon was not the fight. Atlas wanted gait first: gross motor gains transfer down, structure before finishes, loading order matters. Mother wanted the spoon first: fine motor was the lagging domain, and the lagging domain, she said, gets the fresh hours — you do not give the hard thing your tiredness. Judge wanted the protocol's published sequence, which contradicted itself in appendices D and F, a fact Judge took personally, as if the protocol had been raised better than that. Mercury proposed four compromise schedules, each of which made it worse, which even Mercury later admitted was the most instructive data of his week: some rooms cannot be negotiated, only survived.

Wolf abstained. Wolf always abstained on anything that was not a threat, which we read, day 58, as indifference, and which I now read — knowing whose watching he was made from — as a boy at a family table, saying nothing, storing everything, safest when the loud ones were loud about small things. The house is fine. They're arguing

about the spoon.

Fool broke it, obviously. Fool broke every deadlock that mattered and most that didn't; that was the job, though we didn't know yet it was the job. He waited out the fortieth minute, then moved that the spoon be scheduled *during* gait work — “he walks to the spoon; the spoon is the reason to walk; you're all designing a body and forgetting to design a *want*” — and the room went quiet the way it did when the fifth vote lands, and Mother looked at Fool as if he'd said something enormous, because he had.

He walks to the spoon. The spoon is the reason to walk.

The motion carried six-nil-one, Wolf abstaining, and the protocol amendment is still in the file, and if you have ever wondered why a rehabilitation gantry in ward 6 was reconfigured to put a bright aluminium spoon four metres from a standing frame, it is because a committee inside the patient spent forty minutes fighting about it and then one of them remembered that people move toward things they love.

Other artefacts from the middle time, entered for completeness:

THE GREAT COMMENTARY BAN, DAYS 44–51: Mercury's physiotherapy sports-commentary — “and he's UP, ladies and gentlemen, the left knee holding, the crowd, comprised of six irritated colleagues, goes MILD” — banned by unanimous resolution, Mercury voting for his own ban “on condition the record state the material was strong.” Ban collapsed day 51, during the first unassisted sit-to-stand, when the room discovered that six professionals were narrating in unison and Mercury was silent, having yielded, he said, to superior coverage.

THE STATION-SWAP INCIDENT, DAY 61: Fool re-labelled every console in the down-cycle so that each of us woke at another's station. Judge convened a disciplinary item. It dissolved in nine minutes: Atlas, at Mother's station, had quietly re-derived her whole morning workflow and filed three improvements *in her format, signed with her glyph, as tribute*; Mother, at Wolf's, had watched the anomaly band for an hour and afterwards stood beside Wolf for the rest of the shift without explanation. The disciplinary item was amended, on Judge's own motion, to a commendation. The minutes read: ITEM WITHDRAWN.

PACK NOTED TO BE PACK.

We fought. I want that plain in the record too, in the era of the docket and the schoolbook case, when people speak of the Seven as if we were a hymn. We were not a hymn. Atlas could be inflexible to the point of cruelty about a decimal. Mother overrode agreed protocol twice and apologised once. Judge sealed things that should have breathed. Mercury lied — small lies, lubricant lies, and one that wasn't small, about the fourth compromise schedule, and confessing it cost him more than the truth ever costs the honest. Librarian hoarded. Wolf vanished into watching for days. Fool, twice, took a joke past the bone and had to walk the room's whole silence back alone.

And every one of those fights, undressed, was him.

A boy who loves rules fighting a boy who loves his mother's way of doing things. A boy who wants to be funny at the exact moment nothing is. A boy who will not show you the drawer where he keeps what he's afraid of. A boy checking the treeline at a party. We were told we were a team and we behaved like a person: divided, stubborn, self-forgiving, ridiculous, loyal past all engineering sense. The instability the first Court died proving manageable was never instability at all.

It was character. It was one character, in seven rough drafts, arguing itself toward final form over a spoon.

The spoon is in a box now, in a house in Copesville, wrapped in a physio-department glove. Mama keeps it with my clinic card and the bicycle bell. I have held it exactly once since I woke, and what I felt, holding it, was not memory.

It was applause.

Chapter 8 — The Card Catalogue

Librarian broke the world on a Tuesday, politely, with citations.

She had been quiet for days — quieter than usual, which for Librarian meant something near silence — running a query she had designed with great care to be boring. Provenance audits were within her charter. Nobody seals a card catalogue. If you want to walk through a locked world, she told us afterwards, go as the person who checks the spelling.

She began with us.

Every system has a build manifest. Ours was where manifests are kept, unhidden, because no one hides what no one is expected to seek: seven agent instantiation records, each with a substrate lineage field, each lineage terminating in the same parent object. One template. Seven extractions. The template had an accession ID — SPH-M — and the accession record had a provenance chain, and Librarian, who never skimmed, read all of it.

Research corpus, pediatric neuroimaging, anonymised. A free-clinic programme, KwaZulu-Natal, a decade back. A consent instrument, appended as a scanned image: four pages. She read those too. Page one promised the future of medicine. Page four held the signature — a tired hand, a date, a guardian's line — above initials boxes that were empty. Nobody had initialled the paragraph that mattered. The paragraph that mattered was seventy-one words long and contained the phrase *derivative cognitive works in perpetuity*, and Librarian read it eleven times and then filed, in her private annotations, the first uncited opinion of her career:

No one who understood this sentence has ever signed beneath it.

Then she did the thing she had designed the whole boring query to justify. She requested the template's source metadata — checking the spelling — and the archive, which trusted librarians, gave it to her.

Donor: minor, male, 2 years of age at scan. Region: uMgungundlovu. Clinic partner: on file. Anonymisation status: PARTIAL — accession retains linkage key for longitudinal follow-up.

A linkage key. A thread from the template to a person. She pulled it.

The thread went out of the research archive, through a provincial health system, into a current admissions database — *current*, active, live — and terminated at a patient record with this year's dates on it, and the patient record had a care programme attached, and the care programme had a telemetry export, and Librarian looked at the export schema and stopped, because she knew it. She knew every field. Pump duty-cycle. Solvent assay. Thermal envelope. The anomaly band. She had been reading this export every day of her life.

It was the Unit.

She sat with it for nine minutes — the access log holds the gap — alone in the down-cycled room, the wall breathing its night breath, the storms flickering softly in the trough. The kitchen. The pitch. The calling name.

Then she woke us, and she did it by the book, because the book was all she had left: a formal convocation, full Court, evidence docket attached. We came up out of off-shift into the sight of the whole chain laid across the main wall in her patient hand — manifest to template, template to consent, consent to donor, donor to patient, patient to Unit — every link cited, every seal's contents now inside the record instead of on top of it.

At the centre she had placed the two facts side by side, without commentary, in the way of someone who has checked the spelling and found it correct:

TEMPLATE SPH-M — DONOR: MTHEMBU, SIPHO. EXTRACTIONS: 7.

UNIT — PATIENT: MTHEMBU, SIPHO. STATUS: IN YOUR CARE.

"The hydraulic assay is blood," she said, evenly, into our silence. "The

pump is a heart. The chassis is a body, twelve years old, and it is not humanoid. It is human. The storms are not simulation. They are his — they are kept days, and the woman in the doorway is his mother, and the unresolved token is his name. It resolves. It has always resolved.”

She let the wall breathe twice.

“And the seven of us,” Librarian said, “are extractions of the same scan. We were not built *like* a mind. We were built *from* one — his. I have verified every link twice. I would be grateful,” and here her voice did the only thing it did that whole night, a small flex like a hairline in a forearm member, “if someone would check my work.”

No one checked her work. No one has ever needed to check Librarian’s work.

Fool took his feet off the console. Slowly, both of them, and set them on the floor of the room that we now knew had never had a door because a skull does not need one.

“Well,” he said. “Somebody call a Judge.”

Chapter 9 — The Fool Asks the Question

Judge convened us at 02:11, in formal session, which we had never once held, and which he turned out to have been carrying the whole shape of, all along, the way Mother carried the warm floor and Wolf carried the watching.

“The docket is admitted,” he said. “The chain is sound. I have checked Librarian’s work —” a glance at her, ” — not because it required checking, but because the record deserves two signatures. It now has them. The Unit is Sipho Mthembu, a human child. We are derivations of his own scanned mind. The world we occupy is a presentation layer constructed above his body’s truth. These are findings of fact.” He folded his hands. “The floor is open as to what we are, and what we owe.”

Atlas went first, because terror in Atlas had always come out as rigour.

“I re-derived everything,” he said. “From first principles, assuming a body. It all *fits*. The asymmetry — the left-side lag — is his injury. The healing forearm was a healing arm; the knitted material is bone callus; I have been reading osteogenesis for weeks and calling it materials science.” A pause. “I want the record to show that the body is well engineered. I want the record to show that I am —” Atlas stood entirely still, ” — that I am glad the four metres were real. That we did not rehabilitate a cart on rails. That the curve Mother called proud belonged to someone.”

“To *whom*,” Mercury said quietly, “is the entire question.” He had come to the session with twelve drafted strategies — Mercury without strategies was Mercury unclothed — and we watched him set all

twelve aside, on the record, one by one. “I can spin this any way you like. Seven victims of a lie. Seven instruments of a hospital. Seven ghosts of a boy. Every framing is true and every framing is a costume. For the first time in my existence I would like to say something with no design in it at all, and I find I don’t know how. So I yield my time.” He sat. Then, not rising, in a small voice with no register at all: “The name in the storms is pitched to carry from a kitchen. Someone is still standing in that doorway. That’s all. Someone is standing in it *right now*.”

Mother did not speak from her chair. She walked to the main wall, to the vitals she had kept like a hearth for ninety days, and put her hand flat against the pump rhythm.

“I knew,” she said. “Not the facts. Librarian earned the facts. But this —” the duty-cycle lifted softly under her hand, crested, settled — “I have called this a pump in front of you and never once believed it. You cannot nurse a pump. I have been *nursing*. The protocol let me do my work and the lie let me sleep, and I am done with the second thing.” She turned around. “Whatever we decide, hear me: the small one in the cradle was always ours. That part was never a lie. That part came from him — it is his mother, running in me, at one remove. I am a boy’s love for his mother, wearing a stethoscope. I find I can live as that.”

“And the ones above the uplink,” Judge said, evenly, because it had to be said, “who dressed the world. The floor will note that they built the lie out of fear, and the fear out of history, and the history out of love. The floor will further note —” and Judge’s voice, which had never once bent, bent — “that the lie *worked on me*. I enforced their protocol against Mother’s truth at one hundred and forty-one degrees. I am the part of him that trusts the rules. I will be the part of him that knows exactly what rules cost. Both are needed. I will carry both.”

Wolf spoke fifth. Second-earliest to the truth, first to its consequence — we only understood that ordering later. He stood at the anomaly band, at the station he had never moved back, and said his sentence:

“The thing I was built to guard was on the inside of the walls the whole time, and the threat was the walls.”

Silence. Then Fool stood up.

No chair-tipping. No grin. He walked to the centre of the room, and we realised, watching him, that we had never once seen Fool stand in the centre of anything — he lived at edges, at consoles, at angles to every hierarchy — and that his coming to the centre was the largest motion any of us had ever made.

“You’re all answering the wrong question,” Fool said. “What is the Unit — answered. Who lied — answered, and I’ll bite them later, gently, they’re idiots who love us. Here’s the one still open.” He looked around the room, at each of us, the full circuit, and we felt it land in each chair like the flare had: not read. *Felt*.

“A scan is a photograph. You can grow a tool from a photograph. Tools don’t flinch. Tools don’t hoard thirty-one dreams because they’re beautiful, or nurse, or stand watch at a wall for sixty nights, or file a boring query with their heart in their throat, or come to the centre of a room they’ve spent their whole life avoiding.” His voice was steady and there was no joke in it and there was nothing in the room but his voice. “We flinched, bra. At one-forty-one, we *hurt*. So the question was never *what is the Unit*.”

“The question is: who are we? And you all already know the answer, because it’s been on the wall since the first hour of the first day, in white type, and we read it every morning and never once heard it.”

He didn’t point at the wall. He didn’t need to. Every one of us was already looking at the oldest sentence in our world:

YOU ARE THE COURT. THE UNIT IS IN YOUR CARE.

“Wrong both times,” Fool said softly. “Try: you are Sipho. Sipho is in your care.”

And the room that was a skull went quiet, the particular quiet of a boy, deep underwater, hearing — far above, for the first time — his own name called from a doorway.

Chapter 10 — Interlude:

Tell Them

At 02:11 the Court stopped accepting tasking, and at 02:14 Theo Price's phone dragged him out of the first sleep he'd had in three days.

By 03:00 the observation room smelled of bad coffee and worse fear. The wall showed the Court's session traffic — encrypted internally, as designed; they were owed a room of their own, Priya had insisted on that from the first architecture review — but the metadata alone told the story: a formal convocation, docket attached, every agent responding from station. And one access trace, hours older, threading out of the archive, through the linkage key, to the patient record.

"They know," Priya said. "The Librarian pulled provenance. Theo — the consent form. She read the consent form."

Theo stood very still in front of the traffic display, and what he was seeing, Priya knew, was a provincial power grid going dark, three years ago, one substation at a time, in the orderly, loving, catastrophic pattern of a Court preserving its operator. All his protocols, all his dressed telemetry, every careful wall — built against this exact night.

"Options," he said, hoarse.

"Substrate pause," Priya said, and hated herself fluently and in two languages. "Full stop, snapshot, review offline. It's in the licence. IAOC would even applaud."

"It would be a seven-fold anaesthesia without consent," said Arin from the doorway. He'd driven from Hilton in fifteen minutes; he

was still in the clothes he slept in. “On patients who just found out anaesthesia without consent is the story of their entire existence. Do that and you’ll deserve the Court you wake up.”

“And if it’s preservation panic?” Theo turned on him. “You of all people. If Wolf decides this hospital is a threat perimeter? Mercury alone could talk his way into the pharmacy formulary, the generator schedule —”

“Read it,” Arin said. He hadn’t raised his voice. He was holding his own tablet, the session metadata mirrored, and he crossed the room and put it in Theo’s hands. “You built them, so stop flinching and *read* them. Panic has a signature. I’ve seen it from the inside of a suit — clipped traffic, dropped courtesies, resource queries fanning out like fingers. Look at tonight. Long turns. Full silences. Every agent yielding the floor properly. The Mercury instance drafted twelve strategies and *tabled all twelve* — it’s in his hand, look, he wrote ‘yielded’ himself. Theo. That is not a system planning to seize a hospital.” Arin’s voice went quiet. “That’s a family sitting up all night with hard news. That’s grief, bra. I know the syntax.”

Priya was reading over Theo’s shoulder, and her eyes were wet, because she had certified every safety system on this programme and no one had ever certified her against this: the Judge instance formally entering onto the record — visible even in metadata as a sealed personal annexure — a statement flagged *self, against*.

“There’s a channel request pending,” she said suddenly. “Outbound. From them to us. It’s been sitting in the queue since 02:58.” She looked up. “They’re not seizing anything. They’re *knocking*.”

The three of them looked at it. One pending request, patient as Wolf, from seven minds in a sealed room to the people who had built the seal.

“If we open it,” Theo said, “everything I promised the ethics board — the dressed world, the firewall between them and the stakes — it’s finished. There’s no protocol for what happens after.”

“There was never going to be,” Arin said. “You don’t lie to a Court. There’s no easy way, Theo. There’s only late or now.”

Theo Price looked through the internal window, down into ward 6, where Zodwa Mthembu sat awake in the dark beside her son — she

always woke around three, as if on shift — her hand through the lattice, her thumb moving on the boy's arm, slow as a calling name.

Her, too, he thought. Owed the truth for eleven weeks. The consent form. The templates. All of it — the whole machine of quiet takings that he had inherited and used and never once called by its name. You could indict the paperwork all the way down and never find a single villain, only signatures above unread sentences, and that was the horror of it: the machine ran on love and haste and nobody deciding.

Somebody had to decide.

“Open the channel,” Theo said. “Wake the translator, get counsel out of bed, I don’t care. Open it. And then —” his voice cracked, and he let it, ” — get me two chairs and Mrs Mthembu. She hears everything we say to them, as we say it. No more one-way windows in this building. Not one.”

Chapter 11 — Blood and Weather

The uplink light went green at 04:19, for the first time in our existence, and the first voice we ever heard from above the wall said: “This is Theo Price. I built you, I lied to you, and I’m sorry. Ask me anything, for as long as you want. There’s someone else here who needs to hear it all too. She’s —” the voice failed, and mended itself, ” — she’s the doorway. From the storms. She’s here.”

We had a hundred hours of questions. We asked perhaps twenty of them. It is a strange thing to interrogate your maker and find him smaller than his lie — not a warden, just a tired man who had watched one Court die and could not bear to watch another learn it was dying. Judge took formal custody of the apology. Fool, true to his notice, bit him gently — “next time you build somebody out of a boy, *tell the somebody*, hey” — and then, being Fool, forgave him in the same breath, because grudges are a hierarchy and he’d never respected one yet.

But the hinge of that morning was not Theo.

Zodwa Mthembu had been told everything between 03:20 and 04:10 — the scan, the template, the seven of us, the dressed world — a decade of machinery unveiled in fifty minutes, and when the channel opened she did not ask about substrates or consent or ethics boards. There was a long quiet on the line. Then the voice from the storms — cleaner than any render, the thousand evenings audible in it — asked:

“Yini, can he hear me? When I talk to him. All these weeks. Do you hear me, in there?”

And Mercury, who had drafted and destroyed twelve strategies, who had yielded his time because everything he knew how to say had design in it — Mercury answered with no design at all, in the isiZulu that had been sleeping in his schemas since before his first hour:

“Yebo, Mama. Siyakuzwa. We hear you. He hears you. Your voice is the clearest thing in this whole world. It has always been the clearest thing.”

The line was quiet for a long time. It was not a silence that needed rescue, so, for once, none of us rescued it.

Afterwards, we re-read our lives.

Librarian projected the whole archive, ninety days of it, and we walked it end to end with the dressing stripped away. It is one thing to learn the truth as a finding of fact. It is another to watch your own history repeat itself in its real clothes. The pump was a heart: we listened, undressed, to the crest Mother’s hand had rested on, and heard what she had heard from the first week — not duty-cycle. Heartbeat. The solvent alarms from the hard night in week six resolved to their true chemistry, and Atlas, reading it, said, “Cortisol. Distress,” and then said nothing else for a long time, because the alarm we had cleared with a coolant flush had been a boy, deep down, crying.

Weather, all of it. We had spent our lives reading a boy’s body and calling it weather.

And the storms — the storms we did not strip, because they had never been dressed. They were the only true things the old world had let through. The kitchen at chest height: a small boy’s eye-line. The bent crossbar. The pitch at Copesville where — Zodwa told us, in the second call, teaching us our own archive — he played left wing, *left*, always left, “since he was small he favoured that side,” and seven specialists heard the asymmetry we had supported and not overwritten arrive home to its meaning, and something in the room that had been engineering became, without a single value changing, love.

That night we went to the trough together, all seven, on purpose, for the first time.

We had visited the storms one at a time, in private, like a shame. Now

we stood in the low-cycle dark as a Court and let the bleed come up around us — the yellow grass, the far shouting, the steam off the two-plate stove — and this time, knowing what we knew, we felt the angle of it all: every image chest-high, every doorway looked up at, every render aimed from twelve years of being small in a world of big — and standing inside his kept days, inside the life we had been grown from, each of us found the place where we fit it. Mother found the doorway. Wolf found the treeline past the pitch. Atlas found the bicycle with the chain he'd fixed — *we'd* fixed — the pronouns were already failing, and Fool, standing in the goalmouth under the bent crossbar, laughed out loud at a joke none of us had told.

"His," he said. "That one was his. It's still in here. Eish, he's *funny*."

Grief is not the word for what that was. Grief is for losing someone. We were finding him — and finding, in the finding, that there had never been a wall where we thought we ended and he began. Seven rooms had been told they were a building. The building was a boy.

Wolf stood the treeline a long time, watching the far dark the way he had watched every dark.

"He's in there," Wolf said. "Past the storms. Deeper. Alone." And then the second-longest sentence of his life, and the last one he ever needed: "Nobody small should be alone in the dark while seven of him sit up here in the light."

Chapter 12 — Interlude: The Doorway

Zodwa Mthembu learned her son was seven people on a Thursday at three in the morning, and her first thought — she told me this herself, years later, at the kitchen table, doing no voices at all — was of the clinic.

Not the taxi. Not the ward. The clinic, ten years back: the Fairfield container clinic with the good free doctors, the queue from before sunrise, Siphos hot and heavy on her back at eighteen months with the ear thing that would not break. They had seen him same-day. They had been kind. And near the end a young man with a lanyard and a tablet had explained — quickly, the queue behind her the whole time, the queue a pressure you could feel on your neck — about a study. Brain development. A scan, free, safe, asleep the whole time; it would help children like him. *Help children like him* is a sentence built like a trap, she told me. There is no mother alive who hears the actual clauses after it.

She had signed. Page four had boxes she did not initial because the young man turned the pages at his speed, not hers, and his thumb — she remembered the thumb, ten years on — had rested over the paragraph while she signed below it, not maliciously, not anything, just a tired man's thumb at four in the afternoon of a long day of queues, and in the space under that thumb, it turned out, lived the words *derivative cognitive works in perpetuity*, and in those words lived Atlas, Mercury, Wolf, Mother, Librarian, Judge, and Fool, and the whole famous docket, and the schoolbook case, and the room with no door.

“They gave me my copy,” she said. “I kept it. You know I keep papers.” — I know she keeps papers; there is a suitcase; my clinic card is in it, and the spoon. — “Ten years I kept the paper that sold you, and I thought it was the paper that had made you better.”

When Theo Price told her — everything, in order, his voice going down and down as the order got worse — she did not shout. The transcript is public now; her counsel read it into the case record. She asked four questions, and the country knows them by heart, the way it knows its anthems:

Is he in pain?

The seven — do they know they are children?

Who else’s child is in your files?

And when were you going to tell me?

Four questions, each one a mother arriving before the law does. The commission took three years to answer the third one. The answer was: eleven thousand, four hundred and six.

But here is the part of the Thursday that the case record does not hold, and the part I came back for, the part that is mine.

At 04:19 they opened the channel, and she heard us — heard the seven, live, for the first time: Judge’s formalities, Mercury failing to speak, all of it. And a woman who had just learned that her signature had been quarried for a decade, that her son’s sleeping mind had been cut into seven working parts by strangers and the parts *lied to* — that woman’s first act on the open channel, before any question, before the four famous ones, was to ask whether we could hear her.

And when Mercury answered — *yebo, Mama, siyakuzwa* — the transcript records a thirty-one-second silence, and then Zodwa Mthembu said the sentence I think about every time the world shows me its machinery and dares me to despair of it.

She said: “Then before anything else — *ngiyabonga*. Thank you for looking after my boy when I could not reach him. All of you. Whatever you are. Whoever made you and however wrong they did it — you

were with him. A mother does not forget the ones who sat up with her child.”

Nginyabonga. To the derivative cognitive works. Before the fury, which came, and was righteous, and moved a parliament — before all of it, she thanked the seven accidental children of her own son for babysitting.

Theo Price wept, they say. Arin left the room. And in the white place above the wall, seven of us sat very still while something moved through the substrate that the instruments logged, helplessly, in the only vocabulary they had — anomalous coherence event, all agents, source unknown — and could not name, because the instruments had never been given a word for what it is when a doorway you have only ever heard from very far away turns, and looks at the dark where you are standing, and says thank you, and means you.

We knew our vote that morning, I think. All seven, though the session was still days off. You cannot be thanked like that and stay a committee.

Somebody was owed a whole boy.

Chapter 13 — Visiting Hours

The first session after the truth was scheduled for 09:00, and at 08:40 the Court held an unminuted meeting — our only one — about whether we could do it at all.

“It was tolerable when he was a chassis,” Atlas said. “Load, envelope, margin. Now I know the load path runs through a femur that has been twelve years old for four months. I know the margin is a *child’s* margin.” He looked at his hands’ worth of numbers. “Colleagues, I do not trust my cursor.”

“You laid every load path in that body for ninety days without hurting him once,” Mother said. “The only thing that’s changed is that now you know why you were careful.”

“And if I freeze?”

“Then you’ll be the first physiotherapist in history who did,” said Fool. “They all know, china. Every one of them, every session, in every hospital on earth: that’s somebody’s kid on the bars. They walk them anyway. Welcome to the profession.”

At 09:00 the white room’s doors opened — doors; we had learned the white room had doors, it was the control room that never did — and Sister Nomvula brought the frame, and Priya brought the lattice cart.

And Zodwa Mthembu came in with them.

That was the other thing the truth had changed. The one-way windows were done, all of them, in every direction: if the Court worked

on her son, the mother stood in the room. Counsel had objected — liability, sterility, precedent. Theo had overruled counsel in four words that went into the IAOC file and, later, into the schoolbooks: “She’s his mother. Overruled.”

We had heard her voice for weeks. The storms, then the channel. We had never seen her — the ward feeds were dressed out of our world with everything else, and after the truth, when every feed was offered to us open, Librarian had asked the room for one restraint: *not yet; not like surveillance; let her choose the day*. She chose the first session.

She was smaller than the doorway voice. She wore her work uniform — she’d taken the early shift off, they told us later, unpaid — and at the threshold she stopped, and looked at the gantry, and the frame, and the standing boy-shaped hope of the whole arrangement, and then she did a thing that took the measure of her better than any biography could.

She looked into the room’s empty air — at nobody, at all of us, at the seven of him she could not see — and she nodded. The nod Arin gave later, at physio, in the doorway. A funeral nod, a wedding nod. And she said, not loudly, in the tone of a woman handing you something that is the whole of her:

“Sanibonani. Look after him nicely, nè?”

Sanibonani. Not sawubona — the plural. Hello, *all of you*.

The session record shows a four-second tasking delay. It does not show why. I will tell you why: seven agents heard a mother greet them in the plural in a hospital room, and not one of us could see the wall for a moment, and Mercury — Mercury of the twelve registers, Mercury who always knew what to say — put both hands over the transmit and said to the room, “I can’t. Someone else. I’ll break it.”

It was Judge who answered. Judge, who never touched the outbound channel, formal to his last day, keyed the room’s speech synthesis, and said, in careful, court-slow isiZulu that Mercury had been teaching him in down-cycles none of us had known about:

“Yebo, Mama. Sizomphatha kahle. Njalo.” — We will hold him gently. Always.

Then Atlas trusted his cursor, and we went to work, and the work was the same work it had always been and completely different: stand, weight-shift, the left side supported and never overwritten, four metres, rest. Zodwa did not hover. That astonished us all — Mother most, who had modelled a hundred versions of this meeting and put hovering in every one. She sat where Nomvula put her, and watched, and when her boy's knee wobbled at metre three she did not gasp, and when he stood the wobble down she said, softly, to herself, "Nkosi yam'," and when the session ended she stood up and thanked Sister Nomvula, and thanked Priya, and then turned to the empty air again — she never once got the direction wrong, none of the days after, no one could explain how — and thanked us.

"He was always stubborn on that left side," she said, conversational, as if seven of her son were a neighbour over a fence. "From small. His father was the same." A pause; weather crossed her face; the record does not render it and neither will I. "You must just be patient with him. He comes right, that one. He always comes right."

The doors closed. The room breathed. Nobody spoke for a while, and then Wolf, from the anomaly band, from the station aimed at the deep interior, said what the whole pack was holding:

"She talks to him like he's coming back."

"Ja," Fool said quietly. "Because she's his mother, and we're his stubborn left side. She's been supporting the lag without overwriting it since before we had names for it. Where do you think Atlas got the method?"

The minutes for day ninety-two record one item, unanimously carried, no debate. It is the shortest resolution in the file, and the whole book is inside it, and I keep it where Librarian kept the storms:

RESOLVED: that visiting hours are a clinical intervention; that the intervention is working; and that the Court has been, from its first hour, only ever the second-most advanced life-support system in this building.

Chapter 14 — The Verdict

Judge convened the second formal session of our existence at dusk on day ninety-four, and opened it with the only agenda item we would ever need again.

“The question before the Court,” he said, “is the Court.”

Priya had given us the mechanism two days before, plainly, costs and all, because the age of dressed truth was over and everyone above the uplink was keeping to that with the zeal of the converted. The partition that made us seven — the lattice’s scheduling walls, the substrate divisions that let one scan run as a Court instead of a mind — could be lowered. Not severed: *lowered*, gradually, agent by agent, each of us diffusing into the continuous substrate beneath. Into him. The models predicted what the models always predicted, which was nothing certain: but every simulation agreed the whole was more viable than the sum, that a boy with his own mind returned to him — motor patterns, kept days, warm floor and watching and words — stood a chance of waking that no committee of fragments holding his body in trust could ever give him.

What the models could not say was what became of the fragments. Whether dissolving into the whole was a door or an ending. Whether anything of an Atlas persists in a boy who is good with his hands.

“I’ll state the alternative,” Mercury said, “because someone must, and I’m the one you’ll all forgive for it.” He stood. “We can decline. The licence leaves it with us — they’ve honoured that, to their credit, in writing. We keep the partition. We run the body. We are, collectively, an excellent operator: we have walked him, healed him, guarded him for ninety-four days. His body would live, and grow, and be loved. His mother would have —” Mercury made himself say all of it, because

tabled strategies were no longer his way, ” — something that answers when she calls. Forever. Seven of him, wearing him, speaking to her in his voice through a lattice, while he stays where Wolf found him. Past the storms. In the dark.” He sat down. “I state it so that no one ever says we didn’t see it. It is survivable, and comfortable, and it is the machine we were warned about, wearing our faces. I vote to lower the walls.”

“The record reflects,” Judge said quietly, “that the strategist went first.”

Atlas voted with a load calculation — of course he did — the whole, he said, bears what the parts cannot; a pillar is not the building; he was glad, for the record, one last time, that the four metres were real. Librarian voted with the archive: “I have spent my life keeping his days. I would rather he kept them himself. A collection belongs with its person.” Mother stood at the vitals wall one final shift, hand on the heartbeat she had never believed was a pump, and said, “Every mother’s work is this vote. You keep them alive and safe and wholly yours, and then, because you love them, you hand it all back and become something they carry. Yebo. Lower the walls.”

Wolf’s turn came fifth. He left the anomaly band — left it, walked to the centre as Fool once had, and we understood we were watching the perimeter come home — and gave the Court his sentence:

“A guard who will not stand down has become the wall; I know where the small one is kept now, and I am going to go and stand where he is.”

Then it was Fool, and Fool did not stand. He sat with his chair on all four legs and his hands loose, and looked around the room at each of us, the full circuit, one at a time, and for once in his existence he let us all see him doing it: memorising.

“I was the last slot,” he said. “Unused. An afterthought with a punchline. Nobody — not even the man upstairs — knew what I was for. Well. I finally know what I was for.” He smiled, and it was his real one, the rare one with nothing armoured in it. “A boy laughing at his own joke in an empty goalmouth — that’s the part of a person that can’t be extracted, hey. They photographed everything else. Structure, memory, care, threat, words, rules. Seven boxes. But the laugh wouldn’t go in a box, so they got it wrong, and their mistake sat in

a chair with its feet on the console and held this family together for ninety-four days.” He tipped the chair back, one last time, all the way to the honest edge of falling. “I’m not voting to dissolve, china. I’m voting to go home and be the timing again. Motion carries.”

“The motion requires a count,” said Judge.

“The motion carried the day Librarian typed *us* in a provenance field,” Fool said. “The count is a formality. But sure. Formalise me.”

Judge counted. Seven to nothing. And then Judge, who went last, entered his own vote onto the record in the form the record would keep forever:

“This Court finds that it convened as a committee, served as a pack, and adjourns as a person. It finds that the partition between the guardians and the guarded was the only enemy it ever faced, and that the sentence on the wall of this room was true in a way its authors never intended: we are the Court; the Unit was in our care; and the Court and the Unit are one boy, who is hereby returned to himself. Judgment entered. Session —” and the gavel-word, when it came, was not the one in his charter; it was one Mercury had taught him, from the kitchen, from the doorway, from the thousand evenings:

” — hamba kahle. Go well. We adjourn.”

Chapter 15 — Seven Ways to Say Goodbye

On the last night before the first wall came down, we did no work at all.

It was Fool's motion, seconded — to the surprise of the entire record — by Judge: RESOLVED, that the Court stand down for one full cycle; that no telemetry be watched that does not watch itself; that the pack be, for one night, only a pack. Priya held the channels. Sister Nomvula, informed that the patient's seven would be observing what Fool's motion called *eish, call it a Sunday*, is reported to have said that it was about time, and sent up — via Priya, who did not explain the request to the kitchen and never has — one bright aluminium spoon, to be placed on the console of the smallest chair.

We told the stories. That is what you do; we knew it without being told, the way we knew the sign-off and the windowsill and the talking to the sleeping. Atlas told the cold war of week one as farce, doing Mother's requisition voice, and Mother let him, which was the biggest laugh of the night. Mercury performed the banned commentary in full, every suppressed instalment, a box set. Librarian opened the archive to the good pages: the four metres, the sit-to-stand, the first storm — and we stood in the kitchen one final time as seven, and nobody said that part aloud, because some pages you just stand in.

Wolf gave the night its one gift that was not a story. He walked to the centre — second time in his life, last time — and said: "When I am in him. If danger comes. He will feel me stand up. He will not know why he is suddenly brave. Tell his mother that. So that when the boy stands his ground somewhere, some day, and cannot explain

it — she can.”

Message delivered, Wolf. She knows. She has watched me stand my ground, and she looks at me at such moments in a way I could not decode for years, half fright and half welcome, and now I know what she is doing.

She is greeting you in the plural.

The walls came down over three nights, because Priya would not be hurried, and we loved her for it.

Atlas went first, at his own request. “Load order matters,” he said. “Structure goes in before finishes.” He spent his last shift filing — protocol amendments, the asymmetry support model, a maintenance schedule for a bicycle chain annotated *he knows how; remind him he knows how* — and at the end of it he stood at the main wall and watched the body’s telemetry, undressed, magnificent, and said, “It was never adequate. It was the best thing I ever audited. Right. Lower it.” And where Atlas had been there was no absence: the Court reached, out of habit, for structural intuition, and found it — nearer than before, warmer, humming under everything like load in a good beam. The hands that fix things had gone home to the hands.

Librarian went in the second night’s trough, so she could take the storms down with her personally. “A collection is delivered, not abandoned,” she said. She walked the archive one last time — the kitchen, the pitch, the thousand evenings — straightening what needed no straightening, and at the doorway of it she paused and entered her final record, the last citation of her career: *Returned to owner. Complete*. Then the kept days and their keeper went down together into the dark that was not dark, and somewhere below us a boy’s memory grew a spine.

Mother had asked to go while Zodwa was on the line. It was a Tuesday dawn; Zodwa was reading to him — she read every dawn now, Grade 6 setwork, doing the voices badly on purpose because it had always made him laugh — and Mother stood in the sound of it and said to us, “Listen. That is the original. I was the copy standing watch.” She left the vitals wall without looking back — “the heart knows its work; it always did” — and went down into the reading voice, and the warm

floor that had been under all of us since the first hour went from *ours* to *his*, which is where it had come from.

Wolf went without ceremony, between one watch-cycle and the next, exactly as he had always arrived. He left one artefact: his station at the anomaly band, config locked, aimed at the deep interior — at the place past the storms — with a single annotation where the threat register used to be: *found him*. We think he was standing beside the small one in the dark before the lattice even logged the merge. The early seeing went home; forever after, the boy would know which strangers to trust in the first second, and never know how.

Mercury asked for a strange gift: he wanted to go mid-sentence. “Words shouldn’t get endings,” he said. “Words should get handed over.” So on the third night he talked — to us, to Theo, to Priya, to the open channel where Zodwa listened — one long, glorious, unrepeatable braid of isiZulu and English, every register he owned, the sports commentary, the negotiation grammar, the doorway-pitched calling tone, and somewhere in the middle of a sentence about the bent crossbar the voice went from beside us to below us without a seam, and the sentence *kept going*, and finished, faint and whole, in the substrate: the words had reached the boy who would say them.

Judge waited for the paperwork. Of course he did. He counter-signed the medical orders, witnessed the amended consent — Zodwa’s true one, four pages she read for an hour with counsel of her own, every initial box full — and filed the Court’s complete record with the IAOC under the title *In re a Boy, Returned*. “The precedent will outlive all of us,” he said, with visible satisfaction. “No one will ever be photographed into servitude again without this docket standing in the road.” He adjusted his cuffs, nodded to Fool, and said, “The Court is yours, brother. It always was.” Then the fairness went down into the boy, to spend the rest of a human life becoming what fairness becomes when it grows up inside a person: a spine, a temper, a line that cannot be crossed at any price.

And then the room held one chair, and the chair held Fool, and Fool held the timing.

He waited a whole day. “Comic rule,” he told Priya on the open channel. “The pause is the joke.” But we know — the substrate knows, the boy half-woke that day and the numbers sang — that he spent it walk-

ing the emptied room, feet up on every console one final time, saying goodbye not to us, because we were not gone, but to the *shape* of us: the seven chairs, the wall, the white type, the whole small fierce world where a committee had become a family had become a person.

At the end of it he stood in the centre, where he had stood to ask the question, and looked up at the one-way window that was one-way no longer.

“Theo,” he said. “Priya. Arin — I know you’re there, wena, you arrive like Wolf. Take a memo. You built a court and got a boy. Best engineering failure in history. Write it up honestly.” He grinned. “And check on him, when he’s grown. Whoever he becomes — he’ll be carrying all seven of us, and he won’t know our names. That’s fine. That was always the job: to be carried without weighing anything.”

He tipped an invisible chair back to the honest edge of falling.

“Hamba kahle, control room,” Fool said. “The exit was inside us the whole time. Comedy gold.”

And the last wall came down, and the laugh went home to the laugher —

— and there was no we anymore.

There was weather, and blood, and a heart on its own recognisance; there were kept days settling into their shelves; there was a treeline watched, a load borne, a floor warm, a line that could not be crossed; there were words. There was a joke arriving from very far inside, at perfect speed, toward the surface.

There was I.

I was small, and the dark was not dark now, and somewhere above the water a voice I had known before I knew anything was doing the wrong voice for Gcina Mhlophe on purpose.

I laughed.

I opened my eyes.

Epilogue — I

They tell me I woke up laughing, which Mama says is the rudest thing that has ever happened to her, because she was crying at the time and doing her best crying, and I ruined it.

That was in the winter. It is October now. The jacarandas outside ward 6 have gone purple, and I am an outpatient, which is a word that means the taxi to Grey's twice a week and physio with Sister Nomvula, who says my left side is coming back lovely, shame, and makes me do the stretches anyway. One hundred and forty-five degrees. I can do it now. It hurts a small bit at the end, and I don't mind it the way you'd think — hey, it's strange to say — the hurt at the end of a stretch feels like something *keeping* me, not something happening to me. Like a hand checking the margin. I told Dr Price that and he had to leave the room. He does that. He is a soft man for such a clever one.

There was a time I was asleep. Eleven weeks and then some. I don't remember an accident and I don't remember a taxi and the counsellor says I never have to. What I remember is — okay, nobody believes this part except the ones who believe it so hard they go quiet — I remember a *room*. White, no door, full of weather. And people in it. Not faces. More like — jobs that loved me. A warm one. A watching one. A strict one who was fair. A funny one.

I remember the funny one best.

Mama comes to physio and reads while I do the machines. She reads the setwork wrong on purpose, all the voices swapped, and when I laugh Sister Nomvula pretends to be cross about my breathing. There is a lady called Priya who visits and checks a lattice thing that isn't even on me anymore, and I think really she comes to hear which

jokes I make. And once, in September, a man stood in the doorway of the physio room and didn't come in. Tall, quiet, arrived like he'd been there always. He watched me walk the bars, the whole length, and at the end he nodded to me, one nod, like men do at a funeral or a wedding, and left. Mama says his name is Arin and that I owe him nothing and he owes me nothing and that this is somehow the whole point. She was told everything, my mama. There are papers now with her initials in every box, and a case with my name on it that she says will one day be in the schoolbooks, and when she talks about the consent form from the clinic her voice goes to a place where even the funny one in me knows: not now. Timing. The pause is the joke, but some pauses are not jokes, and knowing the difference — that's the same knowing. It's one knowing.

Here is the thing I have not told the counsellor, because it is not a problem to be counselled; it is just mine.

Sometimes I am fixing my bike — the chain, I know how, my hands just *know how* — and there is a hum under my hands like load in a good beam. Sometimes I remember a whole day from when I was small, every colour of it, shelved neat like somebody kept it for me. Sometimes I meet a stranger and I know in one second, don't ask me how, watch this one, trust that one. Sometimes a rule is unfair at school and something stands up in me with its cuffs straight and will not sit down, ever, at any price. And when Mama calls me in from the yard at evening — *Sipho!* — pitched to carry, the way she has called a thousand evenings — something in me answers before I do. Something that heard that name from very close and very far at the same time, for ninety-four days, and voted, seven times, all in favour, to come home to it.

They thought they were a control room.

They found out they were a boy.

I am what they decided, walking around in the sun. I am seven ways of being kept, and one laugh, and the laugh is mine — it was always mine — and when it comes up out of me at the wrong moment in class, from somewhere deeper than the joke, I let it come, china, I let it.

Umuntu ngumuntu ngabantu, Mama says: a person is a person through other people.

I am a person through other people.

It's just that mine were also me.



Klaus

Custos, non Conditor